

“POLITICS IS THE ART OF THE POSSIBLE.”

Otto von Bismarck in a remark to Meyer von Waldeck, August 11, 1867

IN MEXICO, AN EXPEDITION OF British, French, and Spanish forces arrived to collect payment on the money they were owed. After the War of the Reform (see 1858) President Benito Juárez had declared in 1861 that he was placing a **moratorium** on the payment of interest on **foreign debt** for two years. The lending countries disputed his decision, and soon resorted to **armed conflict**. France sent in troops, which faced a defeat



OTTO VON BISMARCK
(1815–98)

One of Prussia's most influential leaders, Otto von Bismarck came into power as prime minister in 1862 and he masterminded the unification of Germany (see 1871). Bismarck built up the army and also tried to develop a German national identity; he fought against the Catholic Church and tried to stem the growth of socialism.

early on, but reinforcements eventually reached Mexico City. Napoleon III saw an opportunity to establish an empire in Mexico.

Farther north, in the **American Civil War**, Union troops attempted, but failed, to capture the Confederate capital, Richmond, by advancing up the peninsula east of **Yorktown**. This was followed by the **Second Battle of Bull Run** (August 28–30, see p.310), which saw 70,000 Union troops defeated by 55,000 Confederates. A few weeks later, on September 17, one of the bloodiest battles of the war took place at **Antietam**, in Maryland, where Union troops suffered around 12,000 casualties and the Confederates around 11,000. Farther west, Union troops under General **Ulysses S. Grant** (1822–85) won a crucial victory at the **Battle of Shiloh**, Tennessee.

In Japan, the **Tokugawa** regime had become increasingly suspicious of foreigners (see 1853), taking measures that included the passing of **anti-foreigner acts** and efforts to expel people. This precipitated attacks on ships from the US, Britain, France, and the Netherlands. In retaliation, in 1863 the US fired on two Japanese ships and French warships fired on—and subsequently burned down—a small village. The following year, France, Britain, the Netherlands, and the US sailed into the **Straits of Shimonoseki** and destroyed Japanese batteries along its coast. They eventually secured a treaty giving them free passage and the right to trade.



Workers hurry to catch their morning train at the Gower Street station on the Metropolitan (underground) railroad in London.

30 THOUSAND THE NUMBER OF PASSENGERS ON THE FIRST DAY OF THE METROPOLITAN LINE

THE SITUATION IN MEXICO became more complex as conservative Mexicans, still angry about their defeat in the War of the Reform (see 1858), capitalized on the fighting between French and Mexican troops (see 1862) and conspired with **Napoleon III** to overthrow the government. As a result, Austrian archduke Ferdinand Maximilian Joseph (1832–67) was invited to become **emperor** of Mexico. He accepted, thinking that he had been voted in by the people, and became **Maximilian I** the following year.

In the US, Abraham Lincoln tried to persuade Confederate states to return to the Union by giving them

the option of abolishing slavery gradually, rather than immediately. Not one state took up his offer, so on January 1, he followed through with his plan and issued the **Emancipation Proclamation**, abolishing slavery in the South.

On the battlefields, Union troops were making serious gains in the south, as General Grant captured the Mississippi port of Vicksburg in July, giving Union forces control over key parts of the Mississippi River. The Union Navy, meanwhile, had captured the port of **New Orleans**, and occupation of the city followed. Farther north, Confederate defeat at the **Battle of Gettysburg**, Pennsylvania,

from July 1–3, had marked a turning point in the war.

In Britain, Londoners were thrilled by the opening of the **Metropolitan Railway**, which ran underground, from Farringdon Street to Paddington. This was the first part

of what would eventually become the **London Underground**, also known as the Tube. Other train companies soon followed suit.



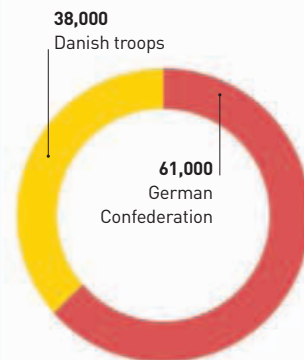
Emancipation proclamation
Abraham Lincoln reads the Emancipation Proclamation before his cabinet members. The decree abolished slavery in the US.



Prussia and Denmark went to war over Schleswig and Holstein.

IN THE ONGOING AMERICAN CIVIL WAR, President Lincoln made General Grant commander-in-chief of the Union forces. A few months later, Union general **William T. Sherman** (1820–91), began his “march to the sea.” Sherman pursued a “scorched earth” policy, destroying rail lines and setting towns on fire from Atlanta to Savannah, Georgia.

Relations between **Denmark** and **Prussia**, part of the German Confederation, had soured. A brief war was the result of a revolt by the Germans in the duchies of **Schleswig and Holstein**, which were living under Danish rule. Prussian troops occupied the territory and by August 1, Denmark gave up rights to the duchies, which were to be placed under joint Austrian and Prussian rule—a situation that would become a future source of conflict (see 1866).



The Prussian–Danish War
The war began when Prussian forces crossed the border into Schleswig, and Denmark was forced to relinquish control of the duchy.

March 9 First battle between two ironclad warships, the USS Monitor and USS Virginia

British annex Lagos

April 6–7 Confederate defeat at **Battle of Shiloh**

August 28–30 **Second Battle of Bull Run** (American Civil War)

September 17 **Battle of Antietam**; costly battle ending in strategic victory for Union

September 23 Otto von Bismarck takes office as prime minister of Prussia

France, Britain, and Spain launch expeditions to Mexico, starting French intervention

Umar Tall conquers Massina in present-day Mali, West Africa

January 1 Abraham Lincoln signs **Emancipation Proclamation** freeing slaves in the US

January 10 World's first underground subway opens in London

22 January **January Uprising** begins against Russian rule in former Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth

1–3 July **Battle of Gettysburg**; largest battle of American Civil War

May 26 Beginning of **Siege of Vicksburg** (American Civil War)

French protectorate established in **Cambodia**

February 1 **Danish–Prussian War** begins (to October 30); part of Wars of German Unification (to 1870)

April 10 **Maximilian I** of Austria (1832–67) crowned Mexican emperor

November–December General Sherman's “march to the sea” in American Civil War

Umar Tall killed attempting to suppress Fulani rebellion, West Africa